

Initiative System

Ways to do Initiative

Initiative can be based on fixed order or reactions.

Fixed Order

At the beginning of time-sensitive situations, call for a roll for initiative. The roll can use any appropriate stat within your system. The stat you prefer for stealth to determine the routs after an initial ambush, for example. You can either make NPCs symmetrical (you'll need statblocks, however), or let the players roll their preferred stat against the NPC's DCs.

For when there's no particular conditions, use an existing proxy for reaction speed within your system, or add one if you don't have it.

You then play in the fixed order, forming rounds akin to those in DnD and Pf2e.

Characters can choose to delay their action to any point later than their initial roll. I recommend letting it happen at no penalty (eg shifting their position in initiative, like pf2e does), as it's just an extra tool for creativity that doesn't break the narrative.

Reaction System

The PCs start (unless they're surprised). If they partially succeed or fail on a roll, the GM gets a reaction, which either means a turn for an NPC, or an environmental effect. If all rolls are player-facing, PCs will likely roll to counteract. This can lead to reaction chains, where a PC keeps reacting in a very dynamic fashion. To prevent this from becoming a spiral, other characters are allowed to break the reaction chain as soon as the first "round" of reactions is over.

Example

Bob has a d8 in Aim and tries to hit NPC Alice. Alice is a bandit wanted in 20 towns, so she has a legendary DC of 11. Knowing this, Bob spends two Sand Points to push his roll to a d12. Unfortunately, he rolls a 6 and a 10, thus taking a full failure. Alice now gets to shoot back at him. Bob rolls Awareness to try to find cover to mitigate the damage. He acts quickly, having no real alternatives, calling for a [risk roll](#). He rolls his d6 against a simple DC of 5 because they're in a saloon full of barrels: it's a 6, so

he manages to dive, taking no damage. He emerges unscathed from the situation, but is now cornered by Alice. How will he proceed?

Bob could instead choose to react with Grit. He heroically takes the bullet in the shoulder, [risk](#) rolling his d10 in Grit against a legendary DC of 11. He uses a Sand Point and manages to succeed by rolling an 11. Eventually he'll have to stop (he does have lead in his shoulder), but for now he doesn't give ground.

It's reasonable for the GM to impose disadvantage on reaction rolls using the same ability that just failed (barring special circumstances).

In a reaction, you can perform quick actions that grant advantage if they present a complication.

Example 2

Alice is fleeing from the police when she sees a man recognize her from across the street. She approaches him to convince him not to call [the law](#), but her Gift of the Gab isn't working (she rolled a 3 and a 2). The man now runs toward the sheriff. Alice reacts using her Gift of the Gab again, but the GM rules that she's rolling with disadvantage. Alice could cancel her disadvantage by drawing her gun and pointing it at the man to frighten him. Naturally, she's in town and there's people around. It might just not be worth it.

After the first exchange occurs, the player might be tempted to keep the chain of events going: as their reaction triggers a reaction from the NPC, and so forth. Other players [can](#) and probably should intervene (unless it's fun for them to watch as their friend keeps digging their own grave with more and more complications. In that case, have fun!).